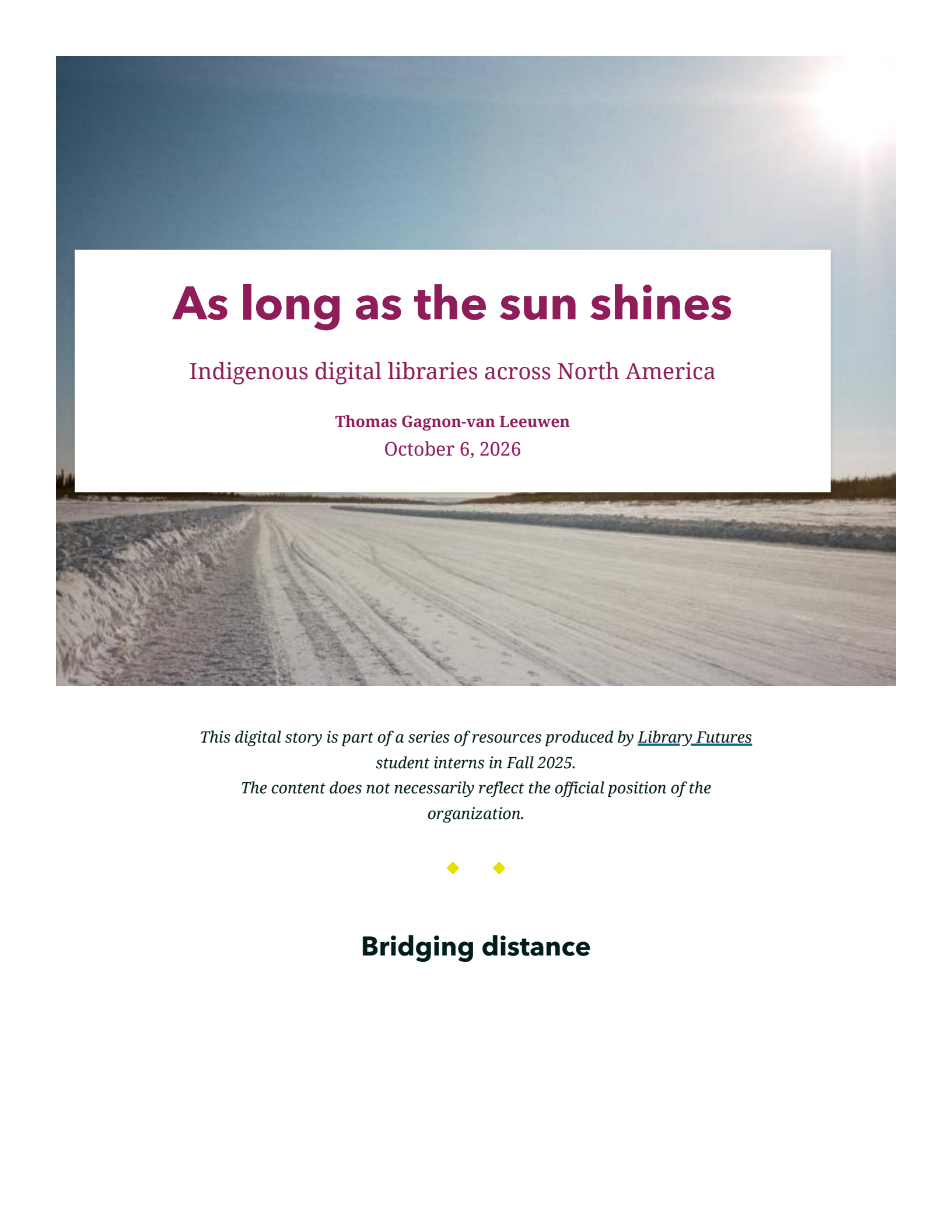




As long as the sun shines

Indigenous digital libraries across North America

Thomas Gagnon-van Leeuwen

October 6, 2026

This digital story is part of a series of resources produced by [Library Futures](#) student interns in Fall 2025.

The content does not necessarily reflect the official position of the organization.



Bridging distance



The Inuvialuit Settlement Region spans 91,000 square kilometers in Canada's Western Arctic.



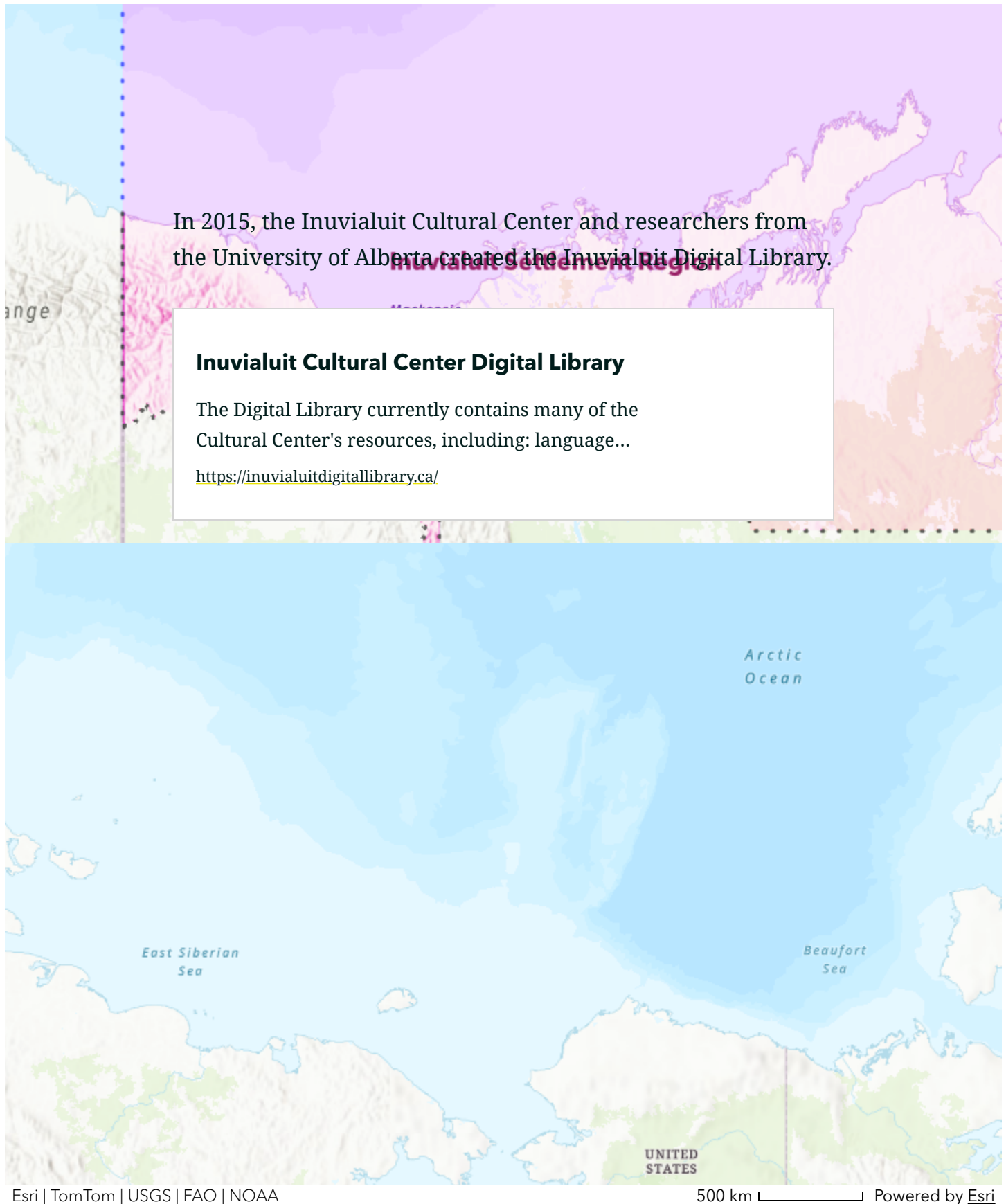
Ice roads and small propellor planes are the only way to reach its most remote communities.



Flights can easily cost thousands of dollars and are often canceled due to bad weather.



Faced with this challenge, the Inuvialuit were trailblazers in creating a digital library to share their culture, on their terms.



In 2015, the Inuvialuit Cultural Center and researchers from the University of Alberta created the Inuvialuit Digital Library.

Inuvialuit Cultural Center Digital Library

The Digital Library currently contains many of the Cultural Center's resources, including: language...

<https://inuvialuitdigitallibrary.ca/>

The Inuvialuit Cultural Center is based in Inuvik, the biggest town in the region, but its photographs, language resources, and oral history recordings are relevant to all the

communities.



Digitizing those resources gave access to remote communities to Inuvialuit language and culture. It also allowed community members who moved to big cities in the south, for school or jobs, to access materials from wherever they are.

Digital libraries present a mix of challenges and opportunities for Indigenous peoples to preserve, reclaim, and share their cultural heritage.

Let's travel together across North America to see how. We'll explore how to organize materials, provide appropriate access, and think about ownership — and we'll meet inspiring people along the way.

Before we embark, I should say that I come to this topic as a non-Indigenous librarian. I grew up in a white, upper-middle-class family in a big city, a fifteen-minute walk from a metro station. In the mid-2000s, Indigenous peoples were all but absent from my high school's curriculum: I learned about residential schools in my first week of university.

My interest in this topic comes from living in Canada's North, briefly in the Inuvialuit Settlement Region and then for seven years in Yellowknife, located on the lands of the Yellowknives Dene and the North Slave Métis. As a queer person, I do have the experience of being othered, and that motivates me to work towards greater justice. I also grew up francophone in Quebec, a place where questions of language, cultural identity, and sovereignty are constantly negotiated.

I think the stories that follow deserve to be better known by *all* librarians and archivists, Indigenous and non-Indigenous alike. We all have a role to play in strengthening Indigenous sovereignty, whether we work as a public librarian in a large system or as the sole archivist for an Indigenous nation.

First, let's talk about power.



Colonial power

Libraries and archives are intertwined with power. The philosopher Jacques Derrida traces the etymology of the word “archive” to the ancient Greek *arkeion*, the house of the rulers of Greek city-states. These rulers not only guarded important documents, but had the power to interpret them.

“ [The archives] in effect speak the law: they recall the law and call on or impose the law. ”

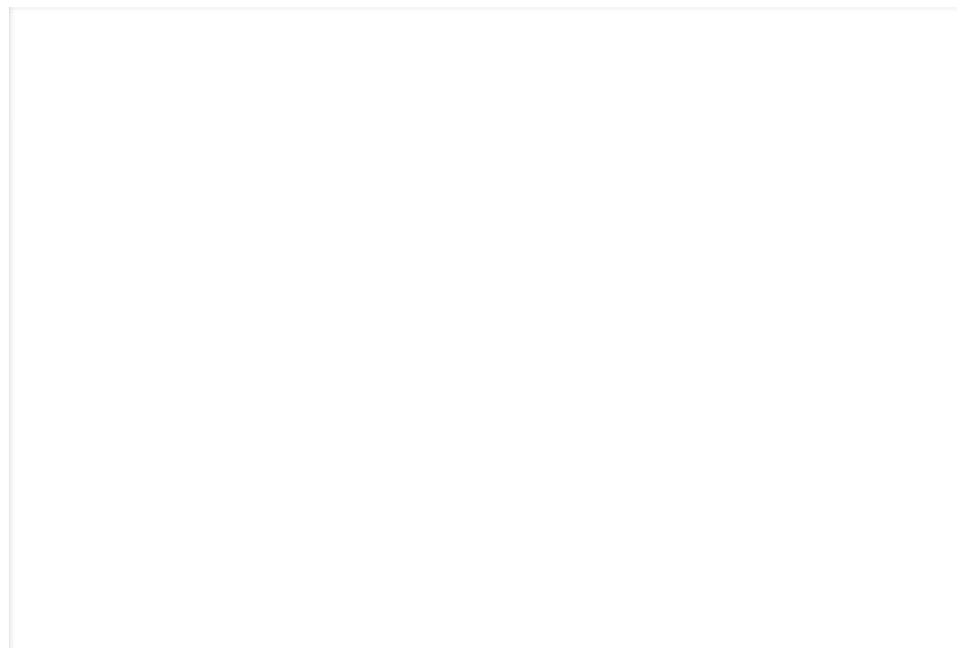
Derrida, 1996.

The archives of colonial states are instrumental in asserting power. Archives are the backbone of a nation's narrative. Deciding what to keep, how to describe it, and what to discard determines whose stories will get told and whose will be ignored.

Colonial institutions have stolen much Indigenous traditional knowledge and culture. Artifacts sit in museums thousands of kilometers away from their home. Some items were never meant to be preserved in the first place.

For centuries, researchers have come into communities, taken whatever they needed, and not shared the benefits they reaped from their research. At worst, they've "borrowed" objects that never returned. We'd like to think this is a thing of the past, but it still happens today.

Digital libraries have the potential to shift power and put control back in the hands of Indigenous peoples. With many priorities competing for limited funding, setting up a digital library is more feasible than setting up a brick-and-mortar one. It can also reach people across huge distances, as we saw with the Inuvialuit Digital Library.



This [miniature canoe](#) is held at the McCord Museum in Montreal, but digitally repatriated in the Nipakanatik digital library, which we explore [below](#).

Digital repatriation allows artifacts to physically remain in colonial museums and archives, taking advantage of their

preservation infrastructure, but exist in digital form for the community to control access and describe them properly.

We begin our journey at the dawn of the digital age, on Wet'suwet'en land, where one librarian used computers to secure a big victory for Indigenous rights in Canada.



The map that roared

In 1982, Gene Joseph graduated from the University of British Columbia with a Master of Library Science degree. She was the first Indigenous person to do so.

Two years later, she returned to her home, the Wet'suwet'en village of Hagwilget, a fourteen-hour drive north of

Vancouver. She had been hired to work on what proved to be a momentous court case for Indigenous people across Canada.

The Wet'suwet'en and Gitksan First Nations had filed claim to 58,000 square kilometers of traditional territories.

And they needed someone to organize the evidence.

Joseph worked to collect, translate, and organize oral evidence from Elders, some of whom were ill or quite elderly. She also compiled thousands of historical documents from archives in Canada, England, and the United States.

Notably, Joseph used computers, which were just starting to show up in office environments, to organize the evidence into a digital library that relied on brand new hardware, software, and database systems.

// While I did not speak the language, I was constantly surrounded and worked with sound and video recordings, translators and linguists who were for the first time having to spell personal, place and spiritual names. We worked closely with the cartographer as he recorded these names onto the new maps of the territories, continually cross checking with the chiefs, elders and researchers. The map was named **The map that roared** by the court. //

Gene Joseph in Doyle et al., 2009.

“A Map that Roared” from Monet and Skanu’u
(1992). Used with kind permission from [Don Monet](#).

The *Delgamuukw* trial ran for 374 days over three years, ending in 1990. The decision was appealed all the way to the Supreme Court of Canada, which ruled in 1997 that the provincial government could not extinguish Indigenous title and traced its contours.

The court also stated that oral history has just as much weight as other types of evidence. An Indigenous librarian, using digital technology, had helped shift what kind of material is valued in archives.

Gene Joseph reflects on her time at the X̱wi7x̱wa Library (3:04)

After the case, Gene Joseph returned to the University of British Columbia to help found the X̱wi7x̱wa Library. To organize the collection, she built upon the work of another trailblazing Indigenous librarian: Brian Deer.



Classifying differently

One way that colonial power shows up in libraries is in cataloguing and classification systems. Systems like the Library of Congress and Dewey decimal classifications attempt to organize the entirety of knowledge from a Western perspective. In doing so, they put marginalized people in a box and label their knowledge systems as “other.”

For instance, under the Library of Congress system, a large number of materials related to Indigenous peoples get confined to the E75-99 range for “Indians of North America.”

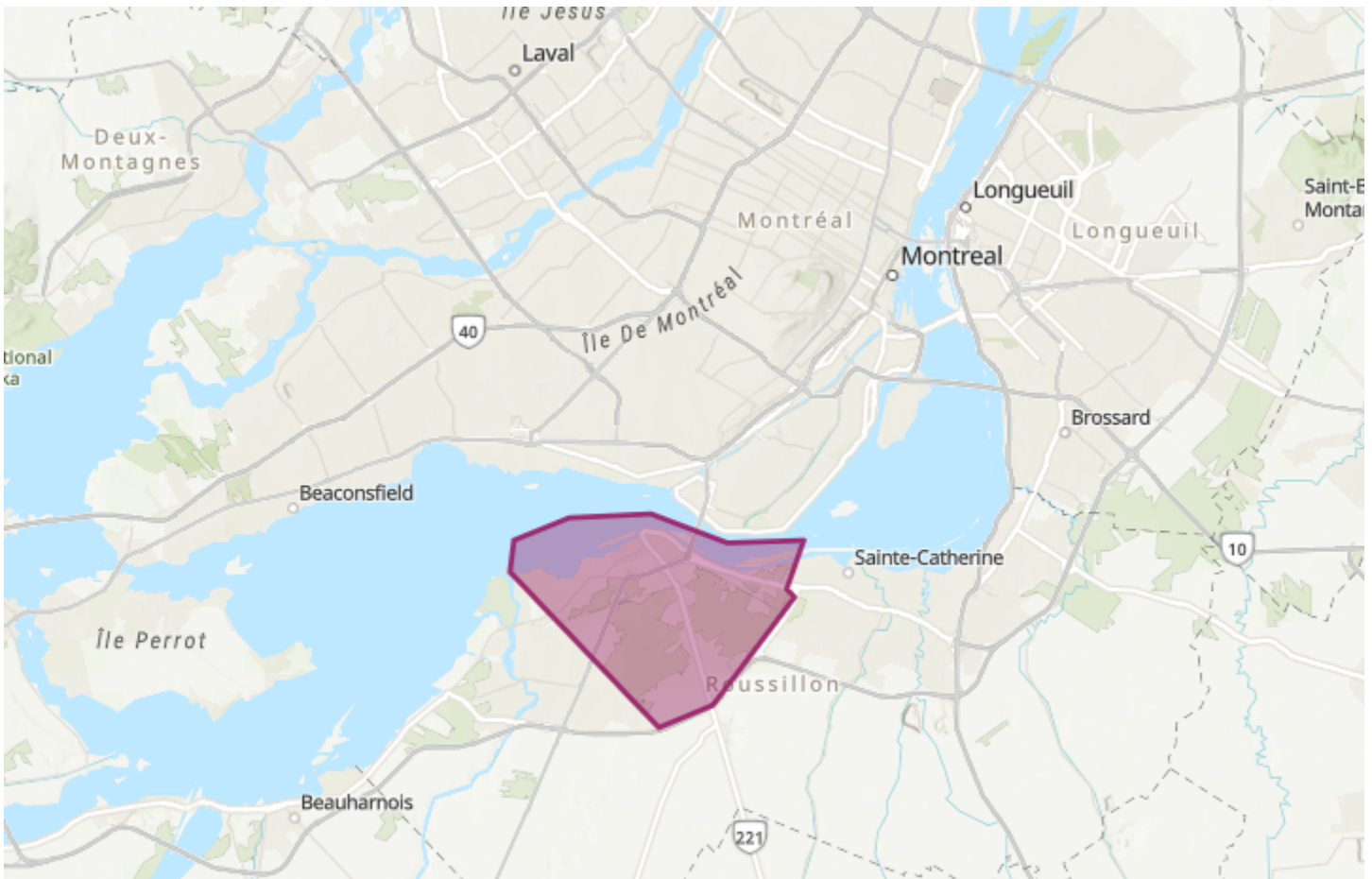
*// What is signified by the placement of Indians
of North America after Pre-Columbian
American and before Discovery of America?
The use of that problematic last phrase
implies the Indians were either gone by the
start of American history, or just didn't matter
enough to be counted as part of it. //*

Webster and Doyle, 2008.

This is nothing new. Sandy Berman, the staunch advocate for more inclusive cataloging and classification, wrote as early as 1971:

// *In the realm of headings that deal with people and cultures – in short, with humanity – the LC list can only “satisfy” parochial, jingoistic Europeans and North Americans, white-hued, at least nominally Christian (and preferably Protestant) in faith, comfortably situated in the middle- and higher-income brackets, largely domiciled in suburbia, fundamentally loyal to the Established Order, and heavily imbued with the transcendent, incomparable glory of Western civilization.* //

Berman, 1971.



Brian Deer decided to do things differently.

He was from Kahnawà:ke, the Kanien'kehá:ka (Mohawk) community across the St. Lawrence River from Montreal.

Doctors said he wouldn't live past sixteen, owing to a lung condition. He proved them wrong and went on to have a rich life as high school teacher, librarian, video store owner, community historian, and university lecturer, with interests ranging from Indigenous religions to the Kahnawà:ke sewer system.

In library circles, though, he is known for his classification system. After graduating from library school in the early 1970s, he was hired by the National Indian Brotherhood, a political body that was fighting the Canadian government's assimilationist policies. Faced with the task of cataloging their library's collection, Deer rejected the existing Eurocentric systems. He decided to create his own.

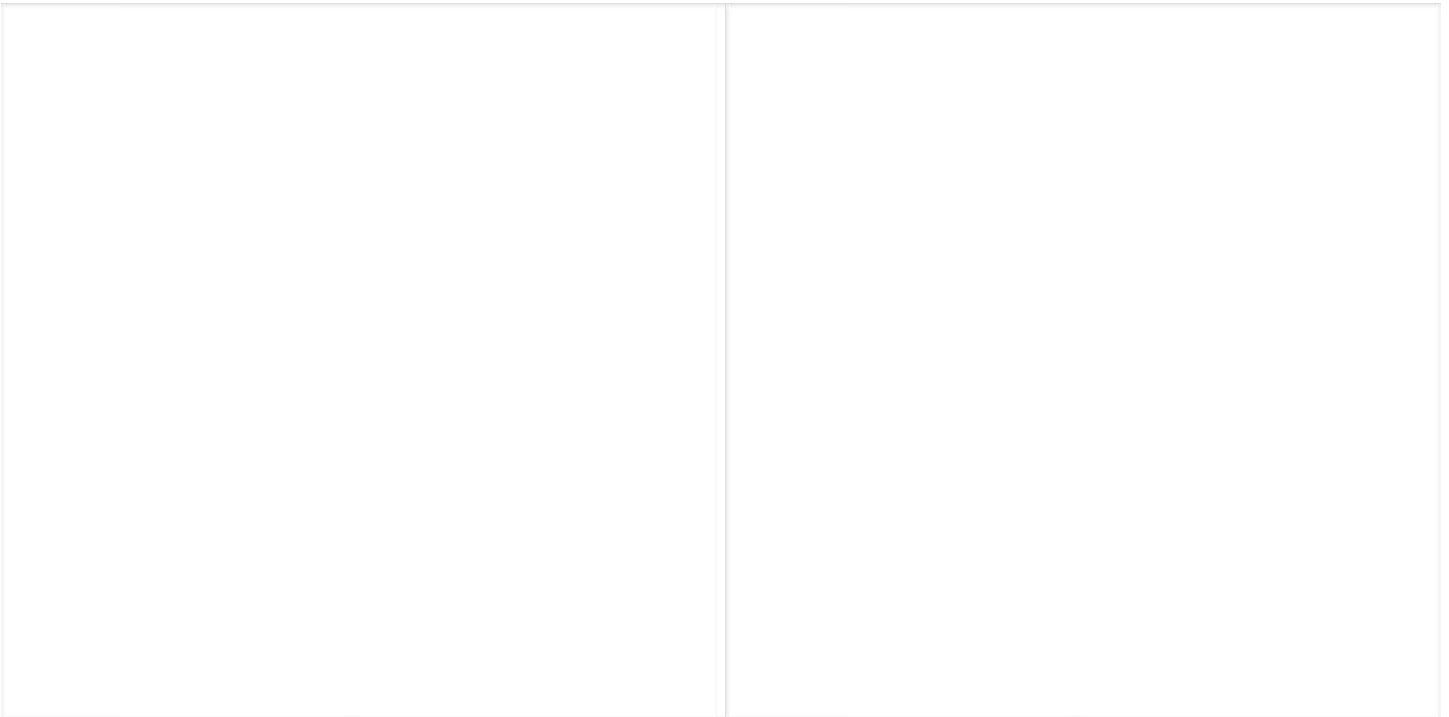
The goal was not to create one universal classification, but rather to create general principles that could be adapted to each context. In Deer's own words:

// Each [system] was drawn up from scratch in accordance with the particular interests and needs of the organization involved, the particular collection of papers they had, keeping in mind that things had to be simple since most organizations did not have a person whose only job was to maintain a library. //

Cherry and Mukunda, 2015.

Call numbers were simple. Subject headings were based on local spellings and language used by the library users themselves.

Today, the Brian Deer Classification has been adapted for use in a number of Indigenous libraries and collections. Here's how it looks at the Xwi7xwa Library, the one Gene Joseph helped build.



Click on the image for the full classification or visit the [Xwi7xwa Library website](#).

Explore the map to discover more institutions that have adapted the Brian Deer Classification. Click on any pin or icon to learn more.



Xwi7xwa Library



Union of British Columbia Indian Chiefs Resource Centre

Brian Deer worked here after his time at the National Indian Brotherhood.



Indigenous Curriculum Resource Centre at Simon Fraser University



χ^wəχ^wéyəm Indigenous Collection at Kwantlen Polytechnic University



Carrier Sekani Tribal Council



Ojibway & Cree Cultural Centre

Gordon H. Hills describes how the BDC was adapted here in his 1997 book *Native libraries : cross-cultural conditions affecting library development in native...*



McMaster University Health Sciences Library



Kanien'kehá:ka Onkwawén:na Raotitióhkwa Language and Cultural Center

Brian Deer himself worked here, in his home community of Kahnawake.



National Film Board: Indigenous Cinema

The NFB used the Brian Deer Classification as the basis for its Indigenous Materials Classification Schema. It's used to catalog the Indigenous Cinema collection.



Aanischaaukamikw Cree Cultural Institute

The Institute endeavoured to adapt the BDC not only for its own needs, but for all of Quebec, as Raegan Swanson details in a 2015 article.

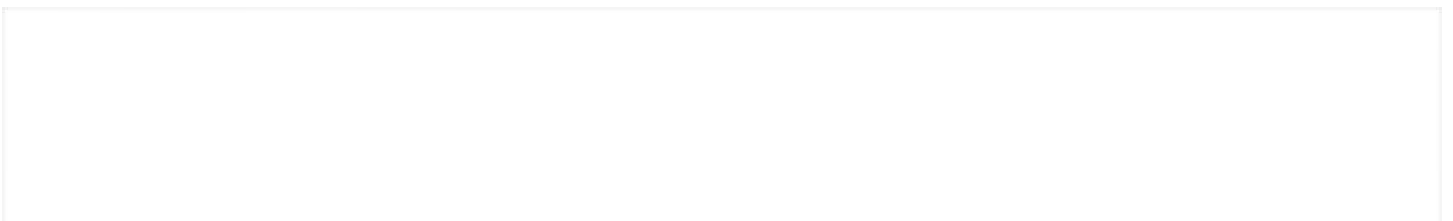
Brian Deer passed away in 2019. Reflecting on his legacy, his brother Philip linked the principles behind the Brian Deer Classification to the nature of oral history in Kanien'kehá:ka culture.

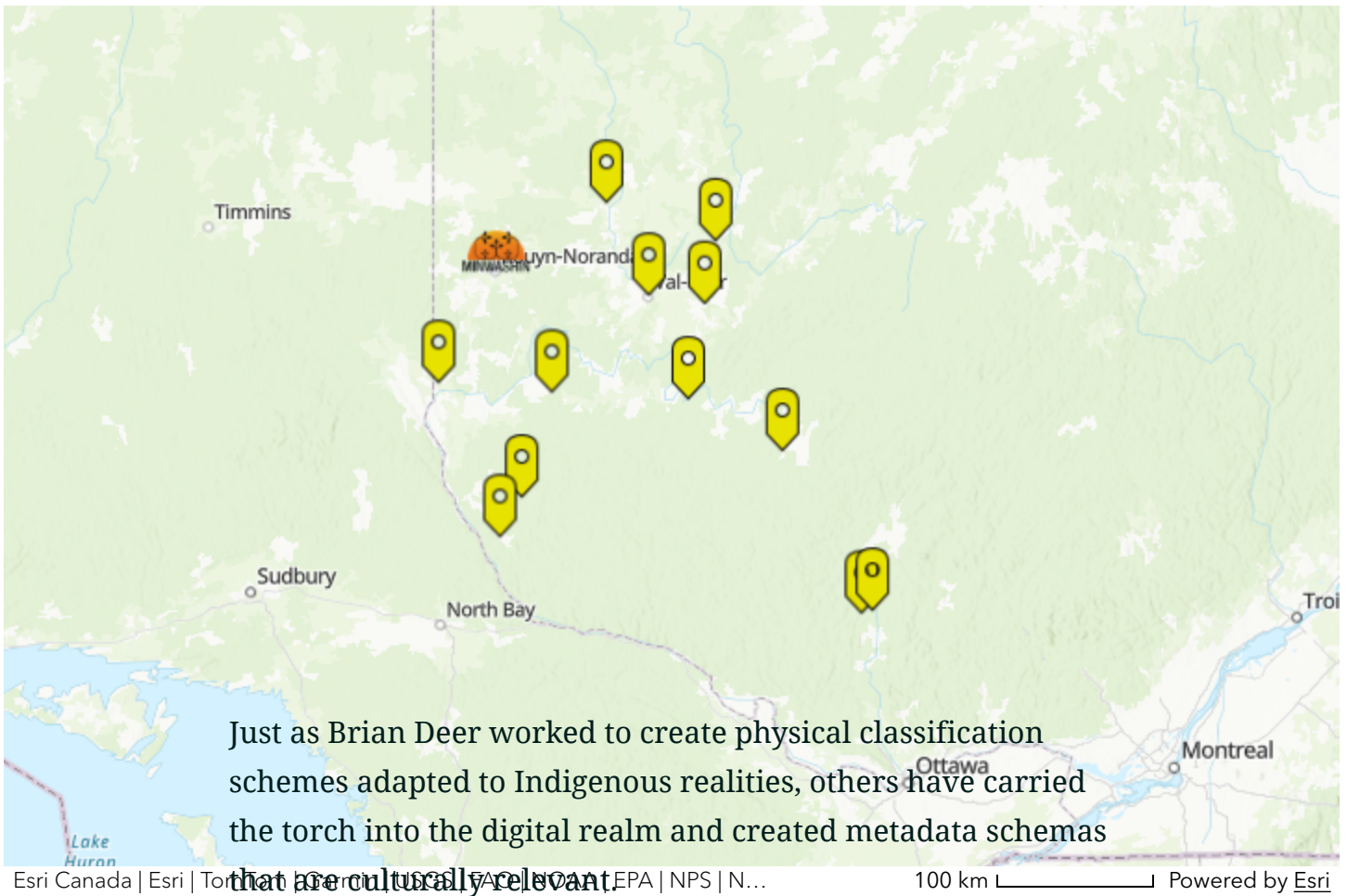
// It is the nature of oral history not to repeat over and over again. We have the Ohen:ton Karihwatehkwen the idea of which, you would never say it the same way twice even the same speaker... Brian was following that oral tradition by cataloguing differently every time that he catalogued a collection. //

Philip Deering quoted in Rowe, 2019.



Metadata in the woods





Just as Brian Deer worked to create physical classification schemes adapted to Indigenous realities, others have carried the torch into the digital realm and created metadata schemas that are culturally relevant.

Minwashin is a non-profit organization dedicated to supporting and celebrating Anishinabe arts, language, and culture. They work in the nine Anishinabe communities and surrounding towns in what we call Quebec today.

In 2019, Minwashin created Nipakanatik: a digital library that preserves Anishinabe heritage for future generations.

Nipakanatik • Home

Virtual Anishinabe heritage collection

<https://nipakanatik.org/s/nipakanatik-en/page/home>

In Anicinabemowin, the Anishinabe language, the phrase *Koki ocitotan weckatc pimatisiwin* roughly translates to “Let’s rewrite our history, let’s restore our way of life.”

Nipakanatik aims to reverse the damage done by centuries of assimilationist policies from colonial governments. In Canada, the residential school system and Sixties Scoop cut off countless children from their culture and language.

Now, with Elders getting older, archives become more crucial than ever.



Search - Search results - Akimak



AKIMAK

TITLE

Akimak

SUBJECT

Arts and crafts
Tools
Kos (Inuit)
Akimak (Snowshoe)

TEMPORAL COVER

19th pylon (Bogotá)
Pylon (Walter)

CONTEMPORARY

Related to an object, as it was

DESCRIPTION

Pairs of snowshoes (akimak) donated by Dr. John L. Todd to the McCord Stewart Museum.

Men and women worked together to make the snowshoes: the former made the wooden frame and the lashing in the middle, the latter braided the ends. The braiding in the centre of the snowshoe had to be extremely strong to support the weight of one person.

The choice and preparation of the wood used for the shaft, as well as the cutting and braiding of the skin strips, required a great deal of technical know-how.

FORMAT

Object

EXTENSIVE

Length: 102.7 cm ; Width: 53 cm ; Height: 2.5 cm

MATERIALS

Wood (Mika)
Shaw
Leather (Pommet)
Cotton
Pony

TECHNIQUE DE FABRICATION

Cut
Woven
Braided
Akimak Band

1

Nipakanatik uses Dublin Core, a metadata vocabulary developed in the early days of the Web and widely used to organize digital collections. But it puts its own twist on it.

500 km Powered by Esri

2

Let's take a closer look at this record, the photograph of *akimak* (snowshoes).

Open it on Nipakanatik's website

Note: the screenshot reflects the record as of November 2025. It may have changed since.

3

For the **Subject** field, Nipakanatik is building its own controlled vocabulary, which it calls *nopimik* ("in the woods"). Staff interview Elders from various communities to capture local differences in Anicinabemowin.

4

Anishinabeg have six seasons, not four. The **Temporal Coverage** field reflects this.

Here, *pitci pibon* refers to the beginning of winter (November-December), while *pibon* is deep winter (January-February).

5

Nipakanatik adds the custom field **Contemporaneity**. It shows that an ancestral practice, such as snoeshowing, is still ongoing.

Unlike mainstream systems that often relegate Indigenous peoples to the past, Nipakanatik's metadata makes it explicit that Anishinabe culture exists very much in the present.

6

Click, drag and zoom into the image to explore more aspects of the record's metadata.

Another innovation of Nipakanatik is its governance structure. Minwashin created an *okwapinaniwak* (circle) of knowledge keepers that steer the project, promote it, and help

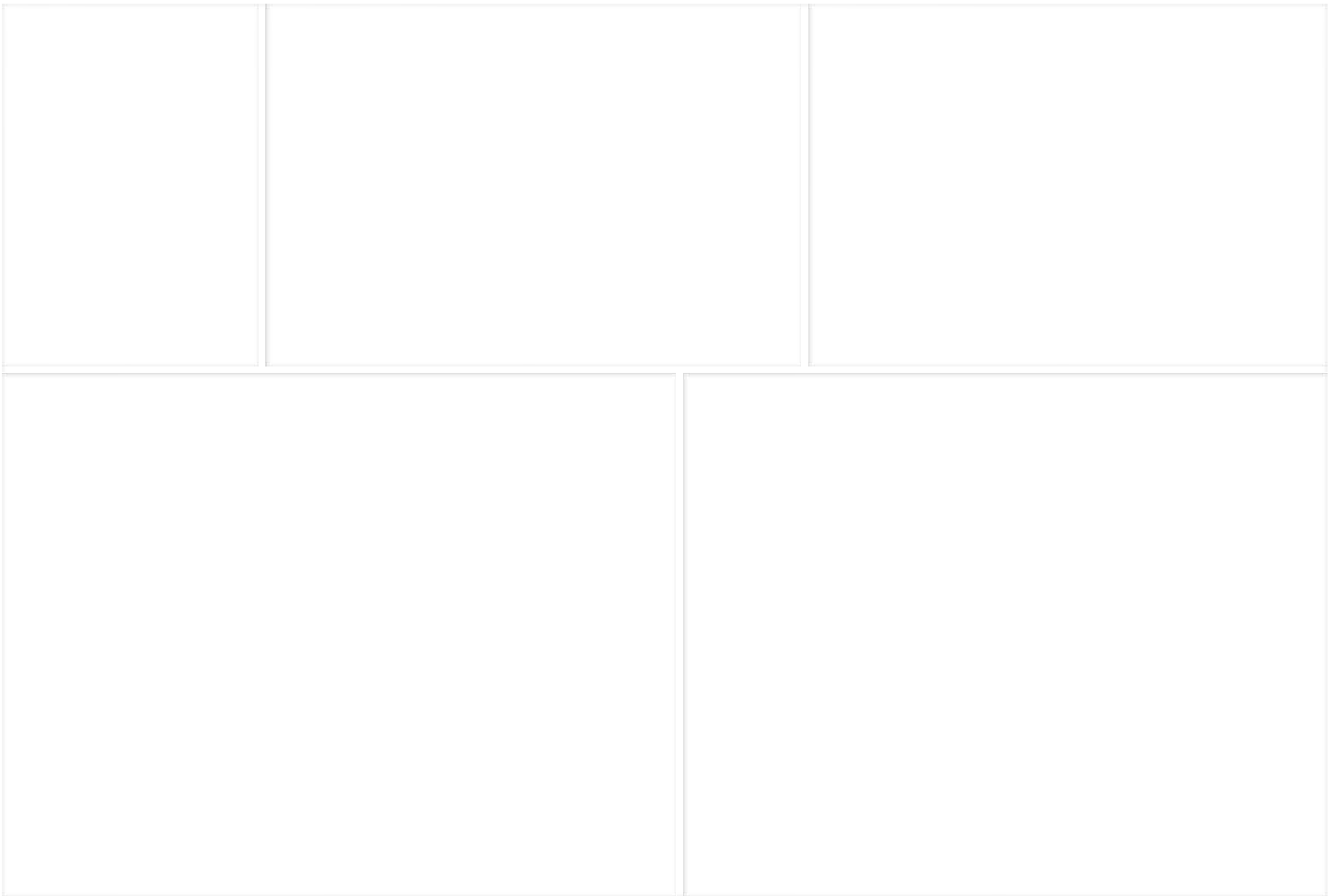
sort through the archives. Nipakanatik's archivist, who is not Anishinabe, can carry out the day-to-day operations knowing that the digital library truly serves the interests of the Anishinabe.

Ethical principles and management of
Nipakanatik. In French with English subtitles. 2:24.

// One no longer works **on** the Anishinabe, but
with them and **for them**. //

Nancy Wiscutie-Crépeau, professor at the *Institut
national de la recherche scientifique* (INRS).

Another way that Nipakanatik works towards cultural sovereignty is digital repatriation. Archives about the Anishinabe — in the form of objects, documents, and photographs — are scattered across North America, in colonial museums and archives as far away as Winnipeg and Washington, DC.



The first three archives are held at the McCord Museum in Montreal: [mackimot](#), [miniature canoe](#), and other [mackimot](#). The last two are from the Hudson's Bay Company archives in Manitoba: [report](#), [photograph](#). Reproduced with kind permission from Minwashin.

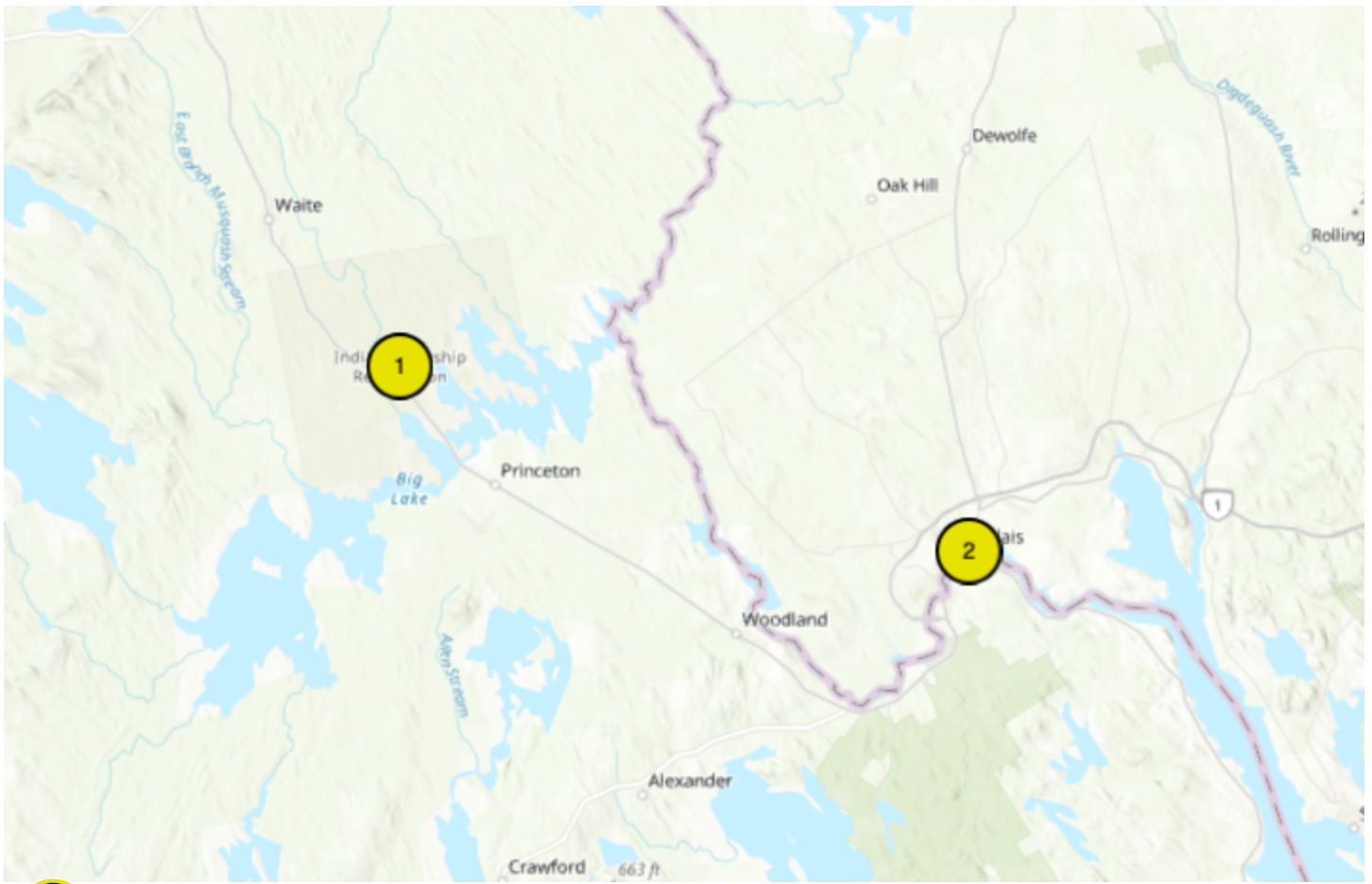
Staff go to these institutions, take high-quality photographs or scans of the archives, and add them to the Nipakanatik collection. Until communities can afford the infrastructure to repatriate and preserve the physical objects, it's a first step towards bringing them home.

And Minwashin are not the only ones doing this.



Decolonizing the commons





1 Province of New Brunswick | Esri Canada | Esri | TomTom | Garmin | SafeGraph | NASA | NGA | USGS | METI/NAS... Powered by Esri

For a particularly striking example of digital repatriation, we travel to Indian Township, Maine.

The Passamaquoddy reservation sits a few kilometres from the border with New Brunswick. Like many other nations, the Passamaquoddy's traditional territory straddles the United States and Canada.

2

Drive thirty minutes down U.S. Route 1 and you'll arrive at the town of Calais, Maine. The St. Croix River separates it from St. Stephen, New Brunswick, and eventually flows into the Bay of Fundy and the Atlantic Ocean.

In March of 1890, anthropologist Jesse Walter Fewkes showed up here with a phonograph, brand-new technology at the time.

He wanted to test it out on the "remnants of the Passamaquoddy" before taking a big trip to the Southwest, as E. Tammy Kim [details in *The New Yorker*](#).

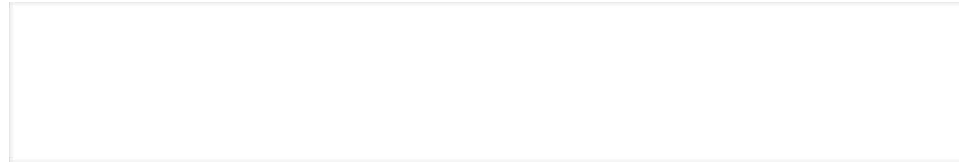
Fewkes worked with locals to record folk stories, songs, and chants onto wax cylinders. They are the earliest sound recordings of Native American voices.

But for nearly a century, they were held at Harvard University's Peabody Museum. The Passamaquoddy didn't have access to the recordings, let alone control over them.

The American Folklife Centre at the Library of Congress first approached the community in the 1980s, returning scratchy cassette-tape versions of the recordings that were barely intelligible. Since then, new technology has restored the recordings, which have been digitized and interpreted by Elders. In 2014, the community started working on the [Passamaquoddy Peoples' digital archive](#) to make the recordings available to the public, on their own terms.

One of them is called *Esunomawotultine*: "let's trade."

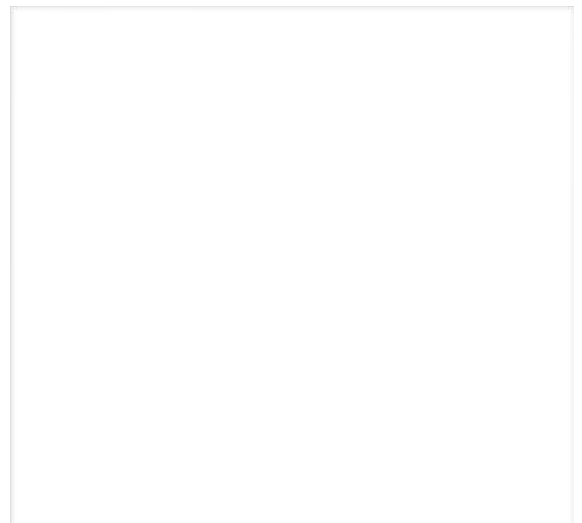
According to Peter Selmore, with whom Fewkes worked to record the song, it is used to encourage trade, building momentum to encourage participants in wigwam to barter and exchange goods. You can listen to it below.



Esunomawotultine, from the Passamaquoddy Peoples' digital archive. Used with kind permission. TK Labels: A, O, NC.

The Passamaquoddy archive uses Traditional Knowledge (TK) labels to inform users how to use the materials. TK labels are a concrete tool that Indigenous communities can use to assert sovereignty over their cultural heritage.

As New York University professor Jane Anderson explains, copyright law fails communities both when the work is under copyright and once it falls in the public domain. If a work is under copyright, it is often owned by the researcher who came in to "document" the community or the colonial institution holding the material. Once it falls in the public domain, anything goes. In both cases, Indigenous communities have no way to control how these materials circulate.



// Is it possible to decolonize the commons?

What would it look like to imagine a commons that is not totally open, but one that has an informed and engaged approach to openness?

//

Jane Anderson, in Halperin, 2019.

Inspired by Creative Commons licenses, the Local Contexts project developed TK Labels to address these shortcomings. The labels' icons are standard, but the accompanying text can be customized based on the particular protocols of the community: some material might be reserved for a certain gender, or a certain season, or for the community only. In the case of the trading song embedded above, the TK Outreach label *Ekehkimkewey* (educational) indicates that the song can be used for educational purposes.

Browse all 17 TK labels

TK Labels are also built into [Mukurtu](#) (*MOOK-oo-too*), the

open-source content management system (CMS) that the Passamaquoddy use for their digital archive. Developed specifically for Indigenous communities, Mukurtu allows for restricting access of certain materials to community members.



The name was given by knowledge-holder Michael James Jampin, from the Warumungu Aboriginal community in Central Australia. It refers to a dilly bag, a small woven bag where elders kept sacred items.

// Novices had to approach the elders who had the obligation and social responsibility to “open up” the items – to share the knowledge that went with them. [But] elders had to “open them up” under the proper conditions – through respectful and “rightway” relationships. //

Christen, 2019.



Bright futures

When I think of my place as a non-Indigenous librarian in all of this, I often come back to the following quote.

// If you have come here to help me, you are wasting your time. But if you have come because your liberation is bound up with mine, then let us work together. //

Gangulu visual artist, academic, and activist Lilla Watson [attributes this quote](#) to an Aboriginal rights group that she was part of in Queensland, Australia.

When it comes to culture and knowledge, I think the liberation of Indigenous and non-Indigenous peoples is indeed bound up together.

Indigenous peoples across the world are reclaiming control

over their cultural heritage in the face of impossible odds — centuries of cultural genocide, theft by colonial institutions, and policies designed to erase them. Turning the tide is every librarian and archivist's responsibility, whether they are Indigenous or not.

But no one is immune from confronting similar forces. Cultural heritage is under attack all over the world, from the destruction of museums, archives, and libraries in Gaza to the attempt to erase queer and racialized stories from school libraries in North America.

The inspiring work being done in Indigenous digital libraries — around shifting power, rethinking metadata, and asserting cultural sovereignty — can be a model for others.

After many years living in the Yellowknife, I left to

attend library school.

The Yellowknives Dene First Nation's motto is, "*As long as the sun shines, the river flows and grass grows.*"

To me, it's a reminder of resilience.

Notes, acknowledgments, and sources

A few notes about language. I tried to match the terminology to the most common accepted terms in the jurisdiction I was referring to in any given section: Indigenous as an umbrella term for First Nations, Métis and Inuit in Canada; Native American in the United States; and Aboriginal in Australia. When possible, I used the names of specific nations and peoples (Inuvialuit, Passamaquoddy, etc.). I used Indigenous when referring to Indigenous digital libraries generally because it is the most commonly used in Canada, where I live. I used units of distance relevant to the jurisdiction I am talking about in any given section (kilometers in Canada, miles in the United States). I used American spelling because Library Futures is based in the United States.

Thank you to Don Monet, Juste Roy (Minwashin), and Donald Soctomah (Passamaquoddy Tribal Historic Preservation) for their kind permission to use materials in this story.

Library Futures mobilizes a community of experts to encourage the adoption of technologies that uplift libraries in the digital age, promoting new possibilities for preservation of and unfettered access to information. Feel free to send thoughts to info@libraryfutures.net.

Below are sources, organized by section, in the order they support the text.

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